

AI for Small Government Contractors

WHAT TO BUY · WHAT TO OWN · WHAT TO SKIP — A VENDOR-NEUTRAL FIELD GUIDE

BUY (SUBSCRIBE)

- **Commodity, low-volume tasks.** General drafting, meeting notes, research assistants — a \$20–\$60/seat tool earns its keep fast.
- **Trials of a new workflow.** Rent before you build. If a SaaS proves the workflow matters, you've learned cheaply.
- **Point tools with easy exits.** Month-to-month, your data exportable, no proprietary lock on your templates or library.

OWN (INSTALL)

- **The workflow that IS your margin.** RFP shredding, compliance matrices, recurring client reporting — if it's your cost of delivery, own the system that does it.
- **Anything touching your corpus.** Past performance, pricing history, client data. Owned systems run in your accounts — nothing leaves.
- **Where vendor churn is fatal.** This market consolidates monthly. A system you own can't be acquired, repriced, or sunset out from under you.

SKIP (FOR NOW)

- **Autonomous anything.** If a tool ships client-facing output without a human gate, it will eventually ship a mistake with your name on it.
- **Win-rate promises.** Nobody can promise proposal outcomes. Tools that do are selling to your hopes, not your workflow.
- **Platforms that absorb your library.** If your past-performance corpus lives inside their walled garden, leaving costs you your own history.

FIVE QUESTIONS TO ASK ANY VENDOR — INCLUDING US

1. **Where does my data live, and who else can see it?** Accept only specific answers: which accounts, which models, what's retained.
2. **What happens when you get acquired or shut down?** If the honest answer is "you lose the tool," price that risk in.
3. **Where is the human gate?** Every AI system needs a named review step before anything reaches a client or the government.
4. **What do I own at the end?** Credentials, documentation, and the working system — or just an export file and a goodbye?
5. **Can you show me the system working — live, on something like my data?** Demos on cherry-picked examples are marketing. Live runs are evidence.

The one rule that survives every vendor pitch: subscriptions are fine for tasks; ownership is for the pipeline your margin depends on. Rent the edges. Own the middle.